ernment and France's Agence Francaise de Developpement (AFD), the project, initially covering 2.82 hectares, was first envisaged in 2017. Some headway was made in 2018, and yet again by the Congress government in 2019, but work started in earnest only in 2020. Today, the project cost has escalated to Rs 856 crore from the initial Rs 97 crore, with the work, on a total of 47 ha., to be completed in two phases. While most of the land for the project lay unused, the encroached bit was cleared after paying compensation.

Under phase I, estimated to cost Rs 351 crore, two additional entry points, Nandi Dwaar and Pinaki Dwaar, have been made, one to cater to devotees coming from the railway station and the other on the road from Indore. This should reduce stress at the existing Shehnai Dwaar. Decentralised parking spaces have also been created to reduce vehicular congestion. A fourth gate is also on the anvil.

The plazas outside the entrances have ticketing kiosks, cloak rooms and can handle up to 20,000 devotees at a time. Entering from the new gates, devotees will arrive at a 'circulation area' from where they can either walk to the temple or take non-polluting transport such as electric vehicles. The circulation area has a corridor that on one side has 25-ft-high sandstone panels on which artists from Sikandra, UP, have engraved various aspects of Shiva's life. On the other side are idols depicting accounts from the various legends of Shiva such as Shiva Vivah, Tripurasur Vadh and Shiva Tandav Swaroop. Each group of statues has QR coded information packets that visitors can access. There is also a pond—the Kamal sarovar with a statue of Shiva and sculpted lotuses. All structures and amenities are named after myths connected to Shiva. "The development of the area provides large open spaces and an immersive experience to devotees, making darshan a pleasant experience," says Ashish Pathak, CEO of the Smart City Project, Ujjain. "The project was designed after a 360-degree consultative process involving the temple trust, priests, the police and cultural and political representatives." An integral part of the project has been the revival of the Rudra Sagar lake, a 17 ha. water body opposite the Mahakal temple that was almost dead owing to the city's sewage lines emptying into it.

While the Mahakal Corridor's focus is on outstation devotees, what about the locals, who line up in massive queues everyday? Granting them a few concessions, the district administration has set aside a 6-8 am slot for them; they also get faster access to darshan than outsiders. "We had formed an association to raise our demands," says Ravi Rai of the Nitya Darshan Bhakt Parivar, a 2,800-strong body of local devotees who go for darshan every day. "We cannot pay for darshan every day and stand in queues for hours and asked the administration to provide us with an alternative access. The development of the temple complex, if it eases devotee movement, should help us too."

Darshan is a big concern among outstation devotees too. "There are two types of outstation devotees, those visiting for the first time and the regulars," says Prithviraj Rishi, a Bhopal resident who visits Mahakal every month. "While any measure to ensure seamless darshan is welcome, it is unlikely that the regulars want to spend too much time with the engravings and statues. The main purpose is darshan. The area around the temple cannot be altered at any cost and the main congestion is there." The project is expected to give tourism a fillip too. "Footfalls are expected to rise from 15 million to 30 million a year. Ujjain's economy is expected to go up by Rs 300 crore," says Asheesh Singh, the district magistrate of Ujjain. "Most visitors now come to Ujjain for darshan and leave soon after. By creating amenities, tours and even a sound and light show in the days to come, we hope to keep the devotees in the city longer. We also plan to promote other temples linked to Mahakal. Devotees staying back will benefit the local economy."

THE BJP AND CONGRESS HAVE BEEN TAKING POTSHOTS AT EACH OTHER WHILE TRYING TO TAKE CREDIT FOR THE NEW MAHAKAL PROJECT

The second phase of the project, with a budget of Rs 310 crore, aims to develop areas such as Begum Bagh, Maharajwada, Hari Phatak in Ujjain city and link it to Mahakal.

With religion and politics now inextricably linked, the government and the opposition vied with each other to claim credit for the project. Ahead of the PM's visit, Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan held a cabinet meeting in Ujjain on September 27 (a picture of the deity 'chaired' the meeting) and used the occasion to attack the previous Kamal Nath-led Congress government. "In 2018, I started the project with a Rs 97 crore budget. The Congress government shelved it when it was in power," Chouhan said on the sidelines of the meeting.

Meanwhile, the MP Congress claims the Kamal Nath government launched the project in 2019 and the BJP has hijacked the credit. "It's all there in the government records," says Congress MLA and ex-urban development minister Jai Vardhan Singh. "The plan to develop the area around Mahakal commenced in August 2019 with a Rs 300 crore budget."

The ruling BJP is leaving no stone unturned to make the inaugural a mega event. A 150-member committee has been set up for the purpose. The CM has said that yellow rice, considered auspicious, should be sent to every house in Ujjain as an invitation, and a *kalash* yatra organised. Cultural programmes have also been planned, including a performance by singer Sonu Nigam. Polls in MP are due in 2023. Mahakal baba's blessings will only be welcome. ■